Easter 3 Year A

Luke 24:13-35

Opening Prayer

Leader
Thanks be to you, O God, that we have risen this day
to the rising of this life itself.
The purpose of God be between us and each purpose;
ALL
the hand of God between us and each hand;
Leader
the pain of God between us and each pain;
ALL
the love of Christ between us and each love.
Leader
O God, you brought us to the light of this new day;
ALL
bring us to the guiding light of eternity.

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Hymn: Guide Me, O Thou Great Jehovah

Guide me, O my great Redeemer,
pilgrim through this barren land;
I am weak, but you are mighty;
hold me with your powerful hand.
Bread of heaven, bread of heaven,
feed me now and evermore,
feed me now and evermore.

Open now the crystal fountain,
where the healing waters flow.
Let the fire and cloudy pillar
lead me all my journey through.
Strong Deliverer, strong Deliverer,
ever be my strength and shield,
ever be my strength and shield.

AWhen I tread the verge of Jordan,
bid my anxious fears subside.
Death of death, and hell's Destruction,
land me safe on Canaan's side.
Songs of praises, songs of praises
I will ever sing to you,
I will ever sing to you.

William Williams (1745)

Window of Wonder

A prayer attributed to St Brigid a fifth-century Irish saint who was famed for her hospitality.

Creative response:

You may like to read this verse from Rev 3:20 before a quiet breakfast..
"Listen! I stand at the door and knock; if any hear my voice and open the door, I will come into their house and eat with them, and they will eat with me."

Closing Prayer

Elusive God,
companion on the way,
you walk behind, beside, beyond;
you catch us unawares.
Break through the disillusionment and despair
clouding our vision,
that, with wide-eyed wonder,
we may find our way and journey on
as messengers of your good news. Amen.

Revised Common Lectionary

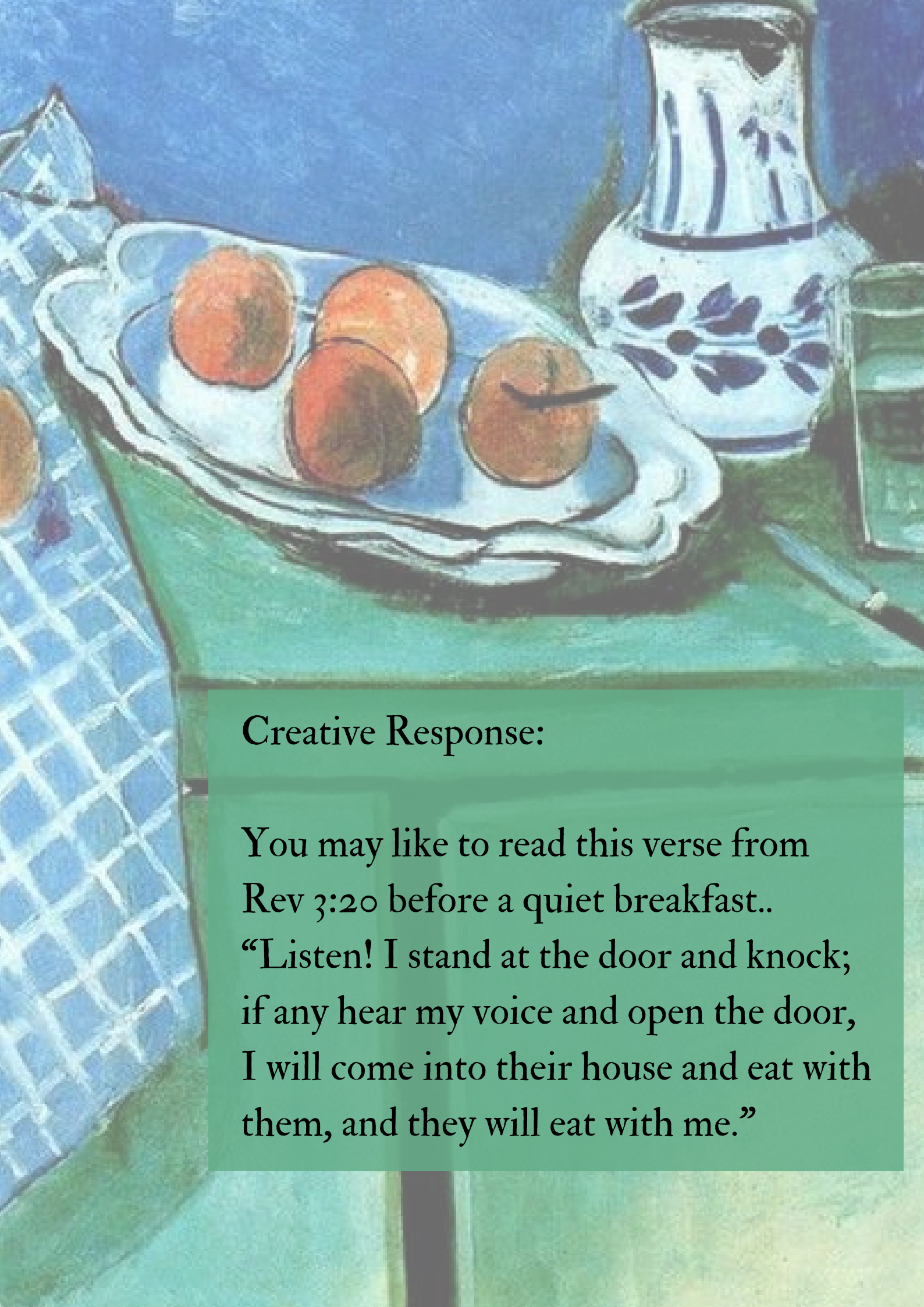
Devotion - Bush Chapel – A Journey into the Sunset

As we continue the Easter story, Luke is the only Gospel that reports a journey at the end of Resurrection Sunday, as two people journey into the sunset, away from Jerusalem on the 11 kilometre road west of Jerusalem to Emmaus.
Luke loves the theme of journey, as a parable of spirituality, found in both volumes of Luke and Acts. For example, the parable of the Prodigal Son in Luke 15 famously illustrates the concept of a journey, where the Prodigal Son makes his journey into the far country, away from the Father's house and love, only to finally return and rediscover this again.
And so, what a beautiful picture Luke paints for us here, as Resurrection Sunday draws to an end, as two disciples head into the setting sun, away from Jerusalem. But as this journey continues, we read that Jesus drew near, and went with them. What a wonderful thought, as we begin to apply this to our own lives. Jesus is happy to draw near, and walk with us on the road and journey of life. Now the name of one of these people was Cleopas, but the other is not mentioned. It is likely that they were husband and wife, walking together, as at the end of the day, they both invite Jesus to stay with them in their home, as Jesus gave the impression that he wanted to travel further.
This little detail also suggests that Jesus never imposes himself upon our friendship and hospitality, but rather responds to our invitation to have him come into our lives and homes. Here I am reminded of a text like Revelation 3:20 – "Behold I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with him, and he with me."

But what was the main point of this journey? Why does Luke record it? Well, to begin with, in verses 19-24, It allows Luke to summarize Jesus' life as a prophet powerful in word and deed before God and all the people, leading to his death and resurrection. Then after this, in verses 25-27, the journey became a moment of "revelation", when Jesus revealed their slowness of heart, and lack of trust to believe in the promises of Scripture about himself (in this case the entire Old Testament). And so the journey that day also became a time of revelation and learning when Jesus drew near in order to open their eyes and understanding of the things concerning Himself.
But it was not until Jesus entered their home at the end of the day, and "broke bread" with them, that they finally recognized who their mysterious fellow traveller on the road really was. Perhaps they had recognized a familiar action with the feeding of the five thousand, as well as the last Passover Supper itself. In any case, their testimony at verse 32 is very revealing:- "Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked with us on the road, and opened the Scriptures to us?"

And so for the two on the road that day, their journey was a time of friendship and learning, as well as a time which finally led to a time of holy hospitality, when Jesus broke bread with them in their own home, at the end of the day, and in this process, revealed his true identity to them. As the chorus puts it, "He lives, he lives, Christ Jesus lives today - He walks with me, and talks with me, along life's narrow way. You ask me how I know he lives. He lives within my heart." So when we find ourselves on our Emmaus road, even though we too might travel with disappointment, confusion, anxiety, and lack of understanding, we truly travel into the sunset of God's blessing and joy, when Jesus draws near, and walks with us, and talks with us, along life's narrow road. May His presence continue to go with us, as well as bless us, now, and forever more. Amen.

Rev Dr Ted Woods.



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